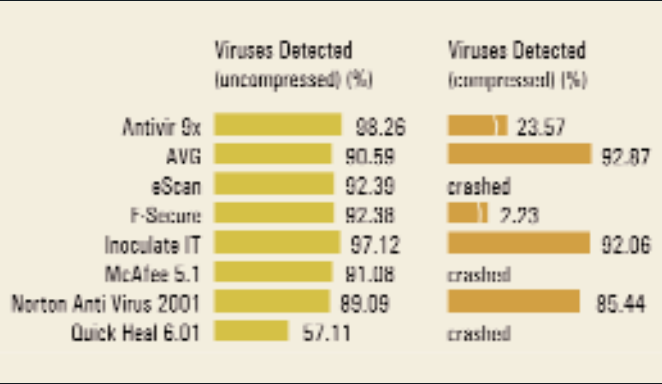




prompting, or performing quarantine, then the time taken increases. That's probably one of the reasons why Norton took as much as 48 minutes for the entire scanning process, while McAfee took 54 minutes. It also seemed very strange that QuickHeal took 51 minutes for a scan, considering that its detection rate was quite low.

There is hardly any difference if you scan for all files (including compressed files). Again, InoculateIT took just 4 minutes to scan the partition with the compressed files. Admitted, InoculateIT is fast, but then it didn't actually manage to clean the infected files very thoroughly. Norton, which had a good cleaning rate too, managed the scan in 40 minutes. Three of the software crashed at varying points while scanning within compressed files.

Eating up resources

It's important that your virus scanner does not eat up a lot of your system resources. Otherwise, if you do a full-system scan, you will have no option but to sit twiddling your thumbs for the 30-odd minutes it takes to scan. Even the auto-protect feature shouldn't hog memory, else your other applications may become slow.

We used a utility called Cache Manager to evaluate how resource-hungry these software were and how much system memory was consumed while these programs were running in the system tray. F-secure took up the most system resources—9.3 MB of the available RAM in the system. Next came eScan with 4.6 MB. One of the leanest programs was AVG, which just ate 2 MB of system resources. However, the lightest of them as far as resources are concerned was QuickHeal, which consumed only 1 MB of RAM.

Another aspect we analysed was the difference in boot-up time. Antivirus software normally checks your machine

during the boot process, so there is an increase in boot-up time. If you are a performance freak, you will want this difference to be minimised even while you get maximum protection. With a 35-second time difference, Norton certainly increased the boot-

up time considerably. On the other hand, Antivir made just a 3-second difference. Therefore, if you happen to use power- and resource-hungry applications such as image-editing or 3D authoring software, then remember that the heavier antivirus software will definitely slow down your other applications while it is running. If your main focus is using your application, you might do better to go in for an antivirus package that is a lesser strain on the system, even if it compromises on some functionality.

Features

All the software should offer standard features such as options for boot sector scans, scanning before startup, creating emergency diskettes, scanning within compressed files, etc. Feature-rich scanners will also include options for scheduled scanning, network scanning, scanning within e-mail, heuristic scanning, etc.

Norton 2001 was one of the most feature-rich antivirus software. It provided for script blocking (preventing viruses such as Melissa), task-based scanning, scanning before you download, scanning

e-mail, etc. With Norton, you can specify the auto-protect feature to work even when you just access a folder and don't necessarily double-click on the executable. You can also specify the file extensions that you want to be checked apart from the default ones.

Even QuickHeal has standard features like scanning inside compressed files (.ZIP, ARJ) apart from other features such as scanning inside compressed executable files, heuristic scans, etc. There is also a File Integrity option to recover a file from unknown virus infection. The other features include live database updates, online protection presence and a Virus List containing virus information. A variety of scanning configurations, such as the possibility of including and excluding specific file types, etc, generating scan reports, scheduled scanning and rescue information, is also available.

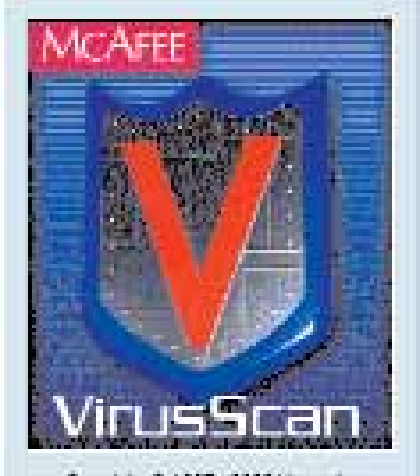
F-Secure has an option wherein the network administrator can configure global security policies for the company and automatically update different servers within the company with the predefined security policy. InoculateIT was a disappointment. After having done so well in its detection capabilities, it lost out on the features count.

Ease of use

Understanding the configuration and interface is quite important if you want to get the best out of your antivirus software. This is especially true of the auto-protect option if a virus is detected. Most antivirus software offer options such as automatic cleaning, prompt for response, delete if the virus cannot be repaired, etc. If you configure this beforehand, the virus scanner will work in the background without unduly disturbing you.

In this respect, Norton offers a number of configurable options, including graphical alerts. McAfee and QuickHeal provide some customisation features as well. One of the simplest to use was F-secure with its totally integrated single-point menu and icons. McAfee uses the concept of panels wherein the options are lined up in one pane and clicking on them gives you multiple options.

Reporting features are equally important if you want to understand the nature of the antivirus attacks you are facing and which files they are originating from. All the antivirus software allow you to create logs of your scan. These logs are automatically generated when a virus is



McAfee sports a cool interface and is rich in features